

like to partner with someone who can help them meet their net zero targets,” says Paul of Equinix. Even for enterprises where this may not be a priority at present, data centre operators know that having a strong sustainability footprint can give them an edge. Most companies are putting in place a series of measures to offset their carbon footprint, like using renewable power and shifting to more efficient cooling methods. CtrlS has set up a solar farm in Nagpur and uses grey water to cool its facilities in Mumbai. Equinix too has set up a captive solar plant and is in the process of building a wind farm.

This is still an industry in transition, and a lot of the technology being introduced, like liquid cooling and high-density cooling, is comparatively

46 | new to India, where cooling requirements are a bit different from places in North America and Europe.

“We are a hot and humid country and are trying to learn from our peers and understand what works,” says Dhar of CtrlS. Talent is another issue. There aren’t enough skilled workers who know how to work with these new cooling systems or high-power GPUs, and companies are collaborating with training institutes to design the curriculum so that it is in sync with what the industry requires. “We don’t have the talent proportionate to what we are going to need in the future, so we have to change the way we are developing our manpower,” says Dhar.

Meanwhile, the global AI boom has also resulted in supply chain challenges worldwide. “Hardware availability and affordability continue to be



“Smaller and emerging cities can make sense where there is strong power availability, improving connectivity, and support from state governments, particularly for AI, cloud, and enterprise workloads”

ALOK BAJPAI

MANAGING DIRECTOR, INDIA,
NTT GLOBAL DATA CENTERS



“AI service providers are looking at India as a big market, and they are shifting a lot of workloads into the country”

MANOJ PAUL

MD, EQUINIX INDIA

a challenge for the industry, particularly for advanced AI infrastructure. High performance GPUs and specialised equipment remain constrained globally, and pricing reflects strong demand from hyperscalers and AI-driven workloads,” says NTT’s Bajpai.

Then there are the regulatory challenges, with every step—from land acquisition, environmental clearance, power connectivity and construction—requiring clearances. The industry is hoping for a single-window clearance system which, when coupled with the tax incentives, can have a truly transformational impact on the industry.

Ashish Nadkarni Group Vice President and General Manager, Global Domain Lead, Enterprise Infrastructure, IDC, cautions that ultimately data centre operators need to think long and hard before deciding how to route their investments. “It’s one thing to build a data centre that is optimised for AI workloads and another thing to build a data centre that is meant for general purpose use, and AI just happens to be one of the workloads,” he says. The latter can be more attractive for companies depending on their requirements, at least in the near term, and that is a decision data centre operators must take.

What’s clear is that the demand for data centres will only accelerate—and the real opportunity lies beyond the metros. As digital adoption deepens across India, Tier II towns are emerging as critical growth hubs. Companies that build robust infrastructure early in these rising markets will be best positioned to capitalise on the next wave of the data centre boom. **BT**